Chapter 10

Boundaries Are Strength

There are rules in your marriage nobody ever wrote down, and you'd defend them anyway. Ask yourself what one of them is actually for, and you may come up empty.

The handbook of Epictetus, a former slave who became a teacher, is the *Enchiridion*, a short field guide to living, and its thirty-third section opens by telling you to settle that question early, before anyone is watching.

> *"Immediately prescribe some character and some form to yourself, which you shall observe both when you are alone and when you meet with men."*

Take the old language off and it says this: decide what kind of man you are before you walk into the room, then be that man whether anyone's watching or not.

You already know how this works. You decided what you'd eat before you got hungry, and what time you'd get up before the alarm went off. So when did you last do that about your marriage?

A boundary is a line you don't cross, and one you don't let anyone else cross either. You decide it ahead of time, so it holds when somebody leans on it. A mood won't do that, and neither will a rule you invent when you're annoyed.

You have them already: boundaries on money, on your kids, on your marriage, and on family. Most of them you've never said out loud, to your wife or to yourself.

Those lines are what the marriage is built on. Take them away and the marriage doesn't get any warmer or easier. It stops holding its shape.

And setting a boundary isn't unkind. Brené Brown, who studies how people handle hard conversations, puts it as clear is kind, unclear is unkind. She says she picked it up in a twelve-step meeting years before she ever wrote it down. Being vague about where your lines are isn't generosity, because it leaves the other person guessing.

The test.

First you need a way to tell a real line from a fake one. A boundary protects something you can name, and a preference is something you want. That's the whole difference, and it decides whether the rule survives the first person who pushes on it.

Take the money one, and ask what it protects rather than what it stops. If the answer is that you don't like being surprised, that's a preference. If the answer is the savings, or the house you're working toward, or the two of you making big calls together, that's a boundary. If you've never answered that question out loud, that's exactly why the rule folds when somebody leans on it hard enough. There was nothing underneath it.

Run it on a second one. You don't let friends complain about your wife to you. What is that protecting? It isn't your comfort. It's her standing with the people around you, which is yours to look after whether she ever finds out you did it or not. Now you can hold the line, because you know what you're holding it for.

Naming it also changes the argument you have with your wife. When the two of you disagree about a rule, you argue about the rule, and that argument has nowhere to go. Nobody ever won "no screens after dinner." But if you can both say what it's for, you're having a different conversation entirely: is this actually what our kids need right now? She might think you're wrong about

the screens and agree with you completely about the kids. That's two people working on the same problem, instead of two people defending positions.

So you don't need her to agree about the rule. You need the two of you aligned on what you're protecting. Get that part right and the rule mostly sorts itself out.

The test also keeps you from becoming a different kind of problem. If you hold firm on everything, that isn't strength. It usually means you never did the work of deciding what was worth holding. So you treat every hill the same, and the people around you learn to stop asking. What doesn't bend is the line. How you say it, when you say it, how much grace you give the person leaning on you: all of that can flex, and should.

Karl Pillemer interviewed seven hundred people who'd been married thirty years or more about what puts the most strain on a marriage. In-laws, money, and the way two people speak to each other all came up. Those are the three places the lines in this chapter live.

What you do to each other.

Start closest in, with the lines between the two of you. Mine are simple, and I suspect yours would be too if you wrote them down. We don't get physical. I don't call my wife names. Neither of us speaks poorly about the other one to friends or family. That's the whole list.

The specific rules matter less than you'd think. Another couple's list would look different and work fine. What matters is that the list holds, and holds is a word that only means something under pressure.

The list protects trust that can take years to rebuild. An ugly sentence can stay with her long after you've both forgotten what the fight was about. An apology matters, and so does what you do after it. The list is there to keep you from making a hard night into harm you both have to live with.

Three things will lean on it. The first is anger. It's easy to keep a line on a quiet weeknight when nothing's wrong. It's a different thing at eleven at night in the middle of something that's gone sideways, when you've got the sentence loaded and you know exactly where it would land. That sentence is always available to you, and not using it is the entire job.

The second is company. Somebody starts in about their wife, and there's a seat open next to them, and it costs nothing to sit down. Think of your friend's picture of your wife as a cup. Everything you say about her pours something in, and it doesn't drain back out. Months later he won't remember the complaint. He'll still have the picture you gave him, and he'll be a little colder to her than he would have been, and he won't know why. It runs both directions. He doesn't get to fill your cup either. A friend telling you something hard and true about your own marriage is a gift. A friend complaining about her to you is a different thing, and you can feel the difference while it's happening.

The third one is the hardest: sometimes you hold the line and she doesn't. She's tired, or she's had a week you wouldn't wish on anyone, and something comes out of her that's on the list. Now what?

Epictetus answered that one a few sections earlier in the *Enchiridion*.

> *"Is a certain man your father? In this are implied taking care of him, submitting to him in all things, patiently receiving his reproaches, his correction. But he is a bad father. Is your natural tie, then, to a good father? No, but to a father."*

He's talking about a son and a hard parent. The part that belongs here is your responsibility for your own conduct. Her crossing a line doesn't give you permission to cross it too.

You hold it anyway.

You can refuse to call her names and also end a conversation in which she's calling you names. Say what you're doing: "I want to talk about this, but I won't keep going while we're insulting each other. Let's come back to it after dinner." Then come back when you said you would, if it's safe.

If it keeps happening, name the pattern and seek help rather than treating each incident as another test of your patience. If you're afraid or someone gets physical, getting to safety comes first. Holding your own standard doesn't require staying in harm's way.

What you do with money.

Money is the clearest case, because the line is a number and the pressure shows up on a specific day.

My wife and I have an amount above which neither of us spends without talking first. It isn't permission, because neither of us is anybody's parent. Past a certain size a decision belongs to both of us, and the conversation is the whole point. When one of us crosses it, we talk about it without making it a fight. Something we agreed to didn't hold, and pretending we didn't notice would cost more than the money did.

The harder version is family. We have people close to us who need money, more than once, and years ago we settled on a rule. You can borrow one time. Pay it back and the door stays open, always, for whatever comes next. Don't pay it back and that was your one time, no matter how bad the next ask gets. A surprising number haven't paid it back. The rule holds anyway.

That doesn't feel like wisdom in the moment. It feels like being the guy who said no to family. Two things lean hard here. The first is that the need in front of you is usually real, since nobody asks for money because things are going well. The second is that you and your wife are two capable adults who may see this differently, and neither of you is being unreasonable.

Henry Cloud and John Townsend, two psychologists who wrote a book called *Boundaries*, put words to why the rule isn't cruelty. People grow by meeting the results of their own choices. When you keep stepping in and covering those results, you haven't spared anyone anything. You've paid it yourself, and after a few times everyone learns who pays.

Say what it protects, because from the outside it can look cruel, heartless, or greedy, and it isn't. You have a family to run and a short list of things you're trying to reach. That means retirement, college maybe, and a stretch of years where the two of you aren't lying awake about money. None of that survives being the person everyone comes to when they've run out of options. That's what the rule is for, and I can say it in one sentence, which is how I know it's a boundary and not just a feeling about money.

You hold it anyway.

How you run your family.

Then there's the shape of the life the two of you are building. It's where the holidays happen, and what you do about religion or politics or the things you were each raised to believe. It's whether there's dinner at the table on a weeknight. It's how the kids get raised, disciplined, and talked to. It's what they're allowed to watch, because there are things a seven-year-old can't unsee. It's what they're allowed to put in their bodies, and until what age, because you'd like them to start from a decent place.

You and your wife get a say in that, and not everyone does. Most of it was never written down. You didn't sit down and formally decide that Sunday night is what it is in your house. It just became true, and it's real, and it belongs to the two of you. That's exactly why someone can walk straight through it without knowing there was anything there.

That someone is usually a parent or a grandparent, and they're rarely being malicious. They raised a family too, and their opinions have thirty years

behind them. They think they're helping, and sometimes they are.

You'll know the moment when it arrives. Say the two of you decided months ago that Christmas morning happens at your house now, because you've got small kids and you're done doing three stops before noon. Then it's October, and your mother mentions, lightly, almost thinking out loud, that she just assumed everyone would come to her like always. Nothing in that is a fight. She hasn't asked you for anything. She's left an assumption on the table, and you can pick it up or let it sit there and turn into December.

The line itself is simple: a decision the two of you already made together is closed. The hard part is who does the work of holding it.

It's easy to hand that job to your wife. You send her to talk to your own mother. Or her father calls you about something already settled, and instead of answering him, you carry it home and set it down in front of her. The line was yours to hold and you gave her the uncomfortable half of it. Do that enough times and she learns that when your family gets difficult, she's in it alone.

So you take the call. And what you say isn't a demand that they change, because you can't make them, and trying is how this turns into a war nobody wanted. Nedra Glover Tawwab, a therapist who writes about boundaries, teaches a version that works: say what you need and what you'll do, not what the other person has to become. In practice that's one sentence from you: "When something is already decided between us, bring it to both of us." If it keeps happening, you stop taking that call alone. You never once told him what to think.

He still gets your patience, he still gets invited, and he still gets to be a grandfather, as he should. What this protects is the family you're actually trying to build. It's a holiday your kids remember as calm instead of a day spent in the back of a car. It's traditions that belong to your house, and a childhood shaped by the two of you rather than by whoever pushed hardest that year.

You hold it anyway.

The part that costs you.

Naming the line is the easy half. Every boundary you set will eventually be tested by somebody who loves you, or somebody you love, and it will not feel like a principled stand while it’s happening. It’ll feel like being the bad guy in your own house.

Your kids won’t complain once. They’ll complain constantly, on a weeknight when you were already finished at four. If you give in that night, you’ll tell yourself you’re picking your battles. But you’ve traded the thing you were protecting for an hour of quiet. Almost every couple makes that trade at some point, and it’s usually why they end up arguing with each other instead of with the kids. One of them wanted peace in the house more than they wanted the thing they’d agreed to protect.

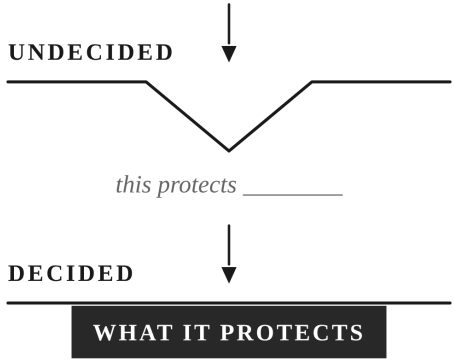
Your mother will be hurt about Christmas. Your father-in-law will decide you’ve gotten rigid. The cousin you turned down will tell somebody you’ve changed.

None of that means you got it wrong, only that you’re the one holding it. That job doesn’t get handed to anyone else in your house, and doing it on the night it costs something is the entire difference between a line you drew and a line you keep.

You’re not holding any of this to win. You’re holding it because your marriage is what’s on the other side of it.

THE UNDECIDED LINE

If you cannot name what it protects,
it is probably a preference.



Putting into Practice

Chapter 10 — Boundaries Are Strength

Mechanism: The Undecided Line

The idea in one sentence: He had rules he'd defend without thinking and had never said what any of them were for, so they folded the first time somebody pushed.

A boundary is a line you don't cross and don't let anyone else cross, and it's only real if you can say in one sentence what it protects. Naming that does two things: it keeps the rule from folding under pressure, and it changes the argument with his wife from the rule itself to what the two of them are actually protecting, which is the argument worth having. The lines live in three places, how they treat each other, how they act, and how they run their family. Naming them is the easy half. Holding one on the night somebody he loves is upset about it is the job.

Keeping your own conduct decent doesn't mean staying in harm's way. You can end an insulting conversation and return when you said you would, if it's safe. If the pattern repeats, name it and seek help. If you're afraid or someone gets physical, get to safety first. These boundaries protect trust that can take years to rebuild.

Lesson: A boundary protects something you can name. A preference is just something you want, and preferences fold.

Challenge: The night it costs you something to hold a line, it will not feel like principle. It will feel like being the bad guy in your own house, and that is exactly the night it counts.

PRACTICE

1. Write down the three or four lines you and your wife actually hold, and next to each one finish this sentence in plain words: this protects ___. Any rule you can't finish is a preference, and it will fold under pressure.
2. When the two of you disagree about a rule, stop arguing about the rule. Ask what each of you thinks it's protecting, and have that argument instead.
3. The next time holding a line would make you the bad guy, notice the trade you're being offered: the thing you were protecting, in exchange for an hour of quiet.